

AFP PHOTO/STR



Chugging into Harmony

KOLKATA Forty-three years after the India-Pakistan war in the east, the people of West Bengal and Bangladesh got a much awaited Bengali New Year gift. On a scorching Poila Baisakh morning, the Maitree Express chugged out of Kolkata station (formerly Chitpur). Almost simultaneously another train by the same name, left Dhaka for Kolkata.

"It's a historic moment for both nations," said External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee as he

flagged off the train. With him were Union Railway Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav, Information and Broadcasting Minister Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi, Governor of West Bengal Gopal Krishna Gandhi and Chief Minister Buddhadev Bhattacharya. Carrying 65 passengers from Kolkata—the capacity is about 368—the train is a symbol of friendship between the two "Bengals". The trains crossed each other at Darshana station, with the

MEMORY LANE: The Kolkata-Dhaka train

Dhaka-Kolkata one ferrying 418 passengers for the 480 km journey.

India and Bangladesh had resumed freight services in 2000 and had signed an agreement to restart passenger train service in 2001. A bus service began in 1996. Security concerns along the rather porous border had also led to the delay in the train service being resumed. The train will run on Saturdays and Sundays.

But the journey had its glitches. Customs and immigration took a long time in clearing the passengers at Gede station before the train entered Bangladesh. A day earlier, live bombs were found on the tracks at Bankimnagar station. Also, a group called Nikhil Banga Nagarik Sangha stopped the train for a few minutes at Aranghata in Nadia district, demanding rehabilitation of Bangladeshi refugees. But this time round, no man's land was a glistening railway track embedded in peace.

by Elora Sen

SIGNPOSTS

KILLED: Biranchi Das, former coach and mentor of child 'marathoner' Buddhia Singh. He was shot dead by three unidentified assailants outside his judo coaching centre in Bhubaneswar.

INDUCTED: Sunil Bharti Mittal,



chairman and CEO of Bharti Enterprises, into the United Nations'

International Telecommunication Union Telecom board.

SENTENCED: Dr Sabeel Ahmed, to 18 months in prison by a London court, for withholding information about terrorist bomb plots in London and Glasgow. His brother Kafeel Ahmed crashed and exploded his jeep into a terminal at the Glasgow airport.

NOMINATED: Scholar Javed Alam as chairman of the Indian Council of Social Science Research. He succeeds Professor Andre Beteille.

VIS-A-VIS MAYAWATI Uttar Pradesh chief minister **versus** RITA BAHUGUNA JOSHI Uttar Pradesh Congress Committee chief

“Whatever rights Dalits and backwards have are due to Ambedkar and there is no contribution of Nehru-Gandhi family.”



SAURABH SINGH

“Mayawati is trying to malign the Congress which has been working for the welfare of all sections of society since Independence.”

EPILOGUE: The 177th birth anniversary of the Dalit icon has become a political mudslinging party.